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Integrating GDPR in the school through digital tools

The teacher as a mediator

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Integrating GDPR in the school through digital tools – The teacher as a mediator - 800 words

The aim of the Erasmus+ project *Spadatas* is to investigate how to support schools in integrating European GDPR (General Data Protection Regulation) norms in their practices, via a research-through-design inquiry.

Through our studies, an ecological (Nardi and O'Day 2000), multiplanes (Rogoff 2008) perspective emerged, centered on the teacher as a main actor, whose professional role affects their own and their students' personal, interpersonal, and community planes of participation, in the innovation of the school practice. This became evident in the case of the implementation of GDPR norms. Schools can be seen as ecologies, characterized by groups of actors (like teachers and students) interacting within a specific "locality", defined by physical spaces, shared culture and tools. Through the digitization of the school, the teachers were the first to experience how digital platforms and social media were compromising the privacy and safety of the school ecology, blending personal and professional ecologies of both teachers and students. This situation was caused by the digitisation of the school, which was accelerated by the Covid-19 pandemic (Marchetti et al 2024, Amo-Filvà et al 2024) imposing a strict regime of distant learning (Garzotto and Marchetti 2021). Moreover, additional challenges were introduced by the increasing use of social media by primary and secondary school students, constantly posting content related to their daily activities. Hence, teachers have seen their sphere of responsibility expanding beyond the walls of their schools, experiencing the need to educate themselves on the correct application of GDPR and at the same time to educate their students in the same subject.

Building on these insights, the aim of the project shifted towards the teacher as a main actor, mediating across other actors and ecologies beyond their immediate sphere of influence. Therefore, the design process focused on providing two main digital tools, which could address the institutional challenges of securing staff awareness and correct application of GDPR in the schools (community planes), and the teachers' challenges in educating themselves on GDPR, while educating their students on the same subject at the same time (personal/interpersonal planes) (Rogoff 2008, Witfelt et al 2024).

The first tool is represented by a series of self-evaluation questionnaires, enabling teachers, and their colleagues (principals and data protection officers, and IT administrators) to gain an awareness about their readiness to secure a correct implementation of GDPR in their schools. Other central stakeholders of this tool are school principals, who will have an overview of the data, to support monitoring and decision-making about existing and new staff, acquiring new updated tools or initiatives for training and information, also targeting families.

The second tool is a digital game-simulation, named *Viral Sphere* (Davis et al 2024), which was developed together with a group of engineering students from the University of Southern Denmark, and students from Oerestad technical Gymnasium. Viral Sphere was developed to address teachers' and their students' desires for resources to foster a dialogue on GDPR with their students. The game leverages network theory (Hogan 2017), to simulate social exchanges on a typical Social Media

network and illustrate potential harm of content sharing. Methodologically the study builds on participatory design supported by co-design and focused ethnography (Haines et al 2022), situated and online. Teachers and students were design partners in the project and contributed to the iterative development and evaluations of the questionnaires and of the Viral Sphere game.

A series of summative evaluations are being performed among the partners and schools in Denmark and Italy, from which we expect to gain insights on how our tool suite can address schools needs for integrating coherently GDPR in their practice, in relation to the three planes of participation (personal, interpersonal, and community) and three intersecting dimensions such as: *Ecological boundaries*, *Technology and practice*, *Dialogue and identity*. These dimensions appeared central through our formative testing. The *Ecological boundaries* dimension deals with the perceived dissolvement of the locality of the school as an ecology, affecting the sphere of responsibilities and consequences for the actions of the actors, which are directly affected by the *Technology and practice* dimension, which deals with how school digital platforms and students' parallel use of social media are reconfiguring the practice and social roles of the actors (mainly teachers and students) in the school. Finally, the *Dialogue and identity* dimension deals with how teachers and students see themselves as being affected by their use of digital platforms in general, and by their involvement in the project. In conclusion, the developed digital tools aim at connecting these dimensions together, to support institutional and actors' awareness in negotiating meaning on the application of GDPR in the school, from their own perspective.

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